

Glimpses of e-Education at Uddipan Badar-Shamsu Bidya Niketon

Asad-Uz-Zaman Asad

“I enjoy doing math on computer using multimedia CD. We learn lessons with pictures, animations and stories, which make lessons easy and understandable.” Hazera Khatun, Class VI

Uddipan Badar-Shamsu Bidya Niketon (UBSBN) is a junior secondary school in the village of Boitpur, Bagerhat. It is participating in a novel pilot program on e-Education, that uses a computer on wheels and interactive, multimedia CD for limited classroom instruction. Students find it enjoyable. So do the teachers. Dipankar Pal, Headmaster of the school said, *“As a part of the pilot program, students in class VI and class VII are getting scope of learning English, Science and Math through multimedia CD. The students are enjoying their lessons. Even weaker students are doing better.”*

UBSBN's experiment with e-Education is another milestone in its participation in the Computer Literacy Program (CLP) since 2005. The program established a Computer Literacy Center (CLC) at UBSBN that is equipped with 4 personal computers, a printer, other peripheral equipment, and trained two teachers in computer usage. The e-Education pilot program leverages on the CLC resources. New Jersey Chapter of Volunteers Association for Bangladesh, VAB-NJ (www.vabonline.org/vabnj) launched CLP with the mission of “Empowering underprivileged youths in Bangladesh through Computer Literacy” in 2005. The project is implemented by D.Net in Bangladesh. The vision of this program is to reduce the digital gap and help develop a knowledge-based society in Bangladesh.

In 2008 VAB-NJ and D. Net started the CTEE (Computer Teaches Everyday English) project to help students learn

English language with proper pronunciation and comprehension, all the while emphasizing on spoken English, which is lacking in regular classes. As a first step CTEE has developed an English teaching CD-ROM that draws from the daily experiences of students in Bangladesh. The contents of the CD-ROM complement the NCTB (National Curriculum and Textbook Board) book for classes VI, VII, and VIII.



The efficacy of the CD and e-Education is being tested in a pilot program in five schools with CLCs. These schools are Uddipan Badar-Shamsu Bidya Niketon, Bagerhat; Mukul Niketon School, Mymensingh; Mamun Smrity Public School, Jamalpur; Brahmanbaria High School, Brahmanbaria; and Gorpara High School, Manikgonj. While the computer lab in a CLC is confined to one room, CTEE uses a computer from the lab wheeled into classrooms. The CD helps students learn English and develop communication skills. In addition to English, CD-ROMs for science and geometry have been identified as well.



On April 15, 2010 I paid a visit to UBSBN to personally observe the e-Education initiative there. I was impressed with what I saw. The school is using English, Science and Math CDs in class VI and class VII; and students are relishing this new teaching-learning tool. This makes learning more active by positively engaging students using colorful pictures and animation. As Mohammad Sohel Rana of Class VI puts it, *“When I learn any lesson of my English book through computer, I don’t forget it. Because this learning is fun, and I can remember the story, picture and text as well.”*



Teachers share the enthusiasm of the students as well, and are eager to have more contents in the multi-media format. As the mathematics teacher Kishor Kumar Mondol observes, *“We have a CD only for geometry. It would be better if we could teach all the primary and secondary math classes using multimedia CD.”*

Many rural schools in Bangladesh today lack adequate teaching staff, and state of instruction is rather poor. However, I came

back from my visit of Uddipan Badar-Shamsu Bidya Niketon with a sense of renewed optimism. The eagerness and enthusiasm of students and teachers there was contagious. CLP’s venture into e-learning, and introduction of *“smart class room”* concept is the right move at the right time. It is only fitting that CLP, winner of Manthan South Asia Award 2009 in the e-Education category, will take this timely initiative and play a pioneering role in realizing the educational goals of Digital Bangladesh.

Asad-Uz-Zaman Asad is an Assistant Director of D. Net, Dhaka. He is pursuing research on e-learning towards his M. Phil degree at the University of Dhaka, Bangladesh.